Turning yield into loyalty

A short POV on Perena's growth problem, and one idea I couldn't stop thinking about

Tashoma Vilini, ahead of the Marketing Lead conversation. Written quickly and informally, so treat it as a sketch, not a finished plan.

The real problem isn't awareness. It's trust and staying power.

From the outside, the numbers say the product works. USD* has paid real yield, it is liquid, and people have shown up. The honest gap is the one Anna has named herself: a lot of those people are smart about their money and will move it the moment they see a better number somewhere else. The goal isn't ten thousand users who pass through. It is a thousand who stay because they trust you.

That reframes the whole marketing job. The benchmark for USD* is not the highest APY in DeFi. It is the bank or the broker the person already uses and already trusts. You win that comparison on two things money usually can't buy quickly: trust, and a reason to let capital settle in.

Who to win, and in what order

The trap would be to chase "emerging-market savers" as one blob. There are three distinct segments with very different acquisition costs, so the plan is to win them in sequence: cheapest and most defensible first, each stage funding the next.

1. Idle stablecoin holders on Solana (win now). Solana already holds billions in stablecoins and stablecoin yield: Maple around $2B, Kamino around $1B, Ondo around $1B on Solana alone. That capital is already on-chain, already in the asset class, and much of it sits idle or rotates on yield. These are your current ten thousand users and the lowest-cost growth there is, because no education is required, only a better and stickier home for dollars already here. The high-value tail of this segment is DAO treasuries and crypto funds, won through BD and radical-transparency reporting.

2. Sophisticated emerging-market savers (the wedge, 6 to 12 months). The real prize, and more reachable than people assume. The audience already exists at scale: roughly 26 million stablecoin users in Nigeria (about 12% of the population, against ~34% inflation), a comparable base in Turkey, and in Argentina stablecoins are over half of all peso exchange activity. A Visa survey found 47% of crypto users across Brazil, Turkey, Nigeria, India and Indonesia already save in dollars via stablecoins. The point: these people already hold USDT to escape their currency, and they earn nothing on it. "The dollar you already hold, but it grows" is a one-sentence pitch to tens of millions of motivated, identifiable savers. The catch that shapes the reach: their rail is USDT on Tron (around 85% of stablecoin payment volume in Africa and Latin America), so you go to their venues, you do not expect them to come to Solana. This is why cross-chain reach and fiat rails are strategy, not vanity.

3. The genuinely unbanked (the vision, later). The biggest story and the hardest, because the acquisition cost is highest: you must build trust, distribution, fiat rails and education all at once. I know this one personally, it is exactly where I aimed JUS in 2023 and exactly why it did not take off. The lesson became strategy: earn this segment after the first two have funded the trust and the rails, do not lead with it.

The spine: win the capital already on-chain (cheap, defensible, fixable with Roots), use that credibility and the matured product to convert the tens of millions of EM savers already sitting in idle dollars, and only then reach for the unbanked.

How to reach them

For the beachhead, I pulled a real audience read (SparkToro) rather than guessing. The crypto-native Solana stablecoin-yield audience is concrete and reachable:

- **They live on X and YouTube, not on Meta.** X is their most over-indexed network (well above the US norm) and YouTube their most-used, while Facebook and Instagram under-index hard. So the mix is X for the thesis-and-transparency drumbeat and KOLs, YouTube for the explainer and education, and you can largely skip Meta.
- **They are already inside the Solana apps.** Their highest-affinity sites are Kamino, Drift, Marinade, MarginFi, Zeta and Step, plus Solscan and DefiLlama. That is the distribution map: co-market and integrate where they already are, an earn-surface in those apps and accurate presence on Solscan, DefiLlama and SolanaFloor, rather than building an audience from scratch.
- **They are unusually heavy AI-tool users.** ChatGPT over-indexes, and Claude over-indexes by more than 250%. That makes AI-answer optimisation a real and cheap channel most stablecoin teams ignore: make sure USD-star is explained

clearly and surfaced well when these people ask Claude or ChatGPT where to earn on stablecoins. It also means the AI-native way Perena and I both work is not just on-brand, it is exactly how this audience already operates.

- **The demographic wedge:** the audience is roughly 77% male and concentrated 26 to 35. Perena's deliberately approachable, non-cyberpunk brand is built to win the under-served end of that, women and the merely curious, which is a cheaper place to grow than fighting for the same degens everyone else chases.

Segment 2 (EM savers) is a different audience entirely, and YouGov reads on Argentina and Brazil prove it. Profiling the personal-finance audience in both (25 to 44) shows a consistent Latin-American pattern, nothing like the crypto-native beachhead: - **Gender-balanced** (Argentina about 51% female, Brazil about 47%), the opposite of the 77%-male beachhead. Perena's approachable brand is a genuine fit here, not a niche bet. - **The channel is messaging and finance media, not alpha chat.** In Brazil WhatsApp is near-universal (about 92%); in Argentina business-and-finance media and newspaper websites over-index by around twenty points. Reach them through WhatsApp communities, the financial press, and trusted finance creators, alongside the on-chain rails (USDT, P2P, local exchanges). - **They are digitally ready** (Brazil over-indexes on computers and tech by nearly twenty points, and on 5G), so the barrier is trust, not capability. - **Their values set the message:** family, quality, frugality, free time, becoming better off. Lead with security and providing for family, "protect and grow what you already have," not upside or yield-maxxing. - **On creative** (from the Argentina read): authentic, real-people, apolitical, well-branded, and earned or educational beats interruptive advertising, which they actively skip.

Two markets is a pattern, not a fluke. I would still run Mexico and Turkey before committing spend, but the headline holds: the EM saver is a gender-balanced, family-minded, WhatsApp-and-finance-media adult whose one barrier is trust, reached nothing like the crypto-native beachhead.

With the audience mapped, three moves.

1. Measure what actually matters. Not volume, not followers, not points handed out. Deposits and retention by channel, every week. The first job is to name the loyal cohort precisely: where did the capital that is still here in month three actually come from. Everything else gets optimised toward that, not toward top-of-funnel vanity.

2. Tell the truth, beautifully. For a savings product, transparency is the marketing. Plain-English explanations of every yield source, where it comes from, and what could go wrong, published on a rhythm. Perena Purple is already the seed of this.

Scaled and made beautiful, radical transparency is how you out-trust a bank. (Sample issue attached separately.)

3. Reward staying, not chasing. This is where the standard crypto playbook fails you, and where I think there is a genuinely different model to run.

The idea: Roots

A loyalty layer that rewards capital for staying, not for arriving.

Why the usual model is the trap. Airdrops and points weighted by deposit size buy exactly the wrong customer. They reward the size and speed of the money, so you attract money that is fast and mercenary by design. When the points slow down, it leaves, and the TVL chart tells the story. You pay to acquire the customer you least want.

Roots flips the weighting from size to time. It fits the family you already have: Seeds are how people arrive, Roots are what grows when they stay. Three mechanics:

1. **Tenure multiplier.** Rewards are weighted by how long your capital has stayed, not how much arrived. A small, patient deposit can out-earn a large, restless one. Withdraw, and your multiplier resets to zero. The incentive now pulls toward exactly the behaviour you want, which is staying.

2. **Referrals that only count when capital takes root.** A referrer earns nothing at deposit. They earn once the capital they brought has stayed past a set window, say ninety days. Overnight this turns your ambassador program from a machine that recruits mercenaries into one that recruits loyal capital, because people only get paid for bringing money that behaves.

3. **Loyalty is the gate to the best things.** The most patient capital gets first access to new vaults and tranches, into Purple, and to the real-world perks and deal flow. Today the best yield is the reward for chasing. Here, the best of Perena is the reward for trusting.

Why it suits Perena specifically. It is on-brand rather than bolted on, it is built to grow the thousand who love you rather than the ten thousand who pass through, and it is a different model from the airdrop race that Anna has said she is tired of. It is also legible to a non-crypto saver, which matters if the consumer and emerging-market direction is real, because "the longer you save, the more you earn, and the more you unlock" is a sentence anyone's mother understands.

It is not a finished mechanism. Sustainability of the reward budget, the exact curve of the tenure multiplier, and the soft-versus-hard treatment of withdrawals all need real modelling. But the shape feels right, and it is the kind of thing I would want to build with you in the first ninety days.

I wrote this because I couldn't stop thinking about the problem after going deep on what you are building. Happy to be wrong on any of it. That's half the fun.